

Point 1 — The Oversight Question

The Metropolitan Police's Palantir "Unified Data Platform": how it escaped scrutiny, and why that is the question

Prepared for: the Office of Iqbal Mohamed MP (Dewsbury and Batley) **By:** Brandon Myers, independent public-interest researcher — brandonmyers.net **Date:** June 2026 **Status:** Built from public sources. **Confirmed facts, reported-but-unconfirmed figures, and the questions they raise are kept strictly separate.** Where the exact contract values cannot be verified against the primary record, that is stated plainly and the point is put as a question to be answered by the Met — not asserted. This is analysis for scrutiny, not a legal opinion or an allegation of fact against any person.

1. The point — and why "why" is the right question

A live, controversial Palantir deployment — one that profiles the Metropolitan Police's **own officers** using their sickness, absence, overtime and **work-device geolocation** data — proceeded **without Deputy Mayor approval, without a published Policing and Crime Decision, and without the public and London Assembly scrutiny that a £500,000 contract attracts**. That much is not in dispute.

The reporting indicates this happened because the work was contracted **below the £500,000 oversight threshold** — and that it may have been run across **more than one sub-threshold contract**. The exact figures are **reported, not yet confirmed against the primary record** (see §4). But the accountability question does not depend on the pence. It is simply: **why did a programme of this sensitivity end up structured so that no one had to approve it, publish a decision, or answer for it — and who decided that?**

That is the unbreakable ground. A "why" question cannot be answered with *"we do not hold that information,"* and a refusal to explain *why* is itself the finding.

2. The questions to put (the spine)

Anchored to confirmed facts or phrased conditionally, so there is no premise to dispute:

1. **How many** contracts did the MPS enter into with Palantir for the Unified Data Platform, **what was the value of each**, and **what is the combined total including any extension?**
2. If the programme was delivered under **more than one contract**, **why were they not aggregated** for the £500,000 threshold at which Deputy Mayor approval is required (MOPAC Scheme of Delegation and Consent, para 4.8) — and was the value estimated in accordance with **Schedule 3 of the Procurement Act 2023**, which requires aggregation and prohibits artificial subdivision?

3. **Why** was this pilot not brought to the Deputy Mayor for approval, with a published Policing and Crime Decision?
 4. **Why** is the extension cost withheld as "*commercially sensitive*" — what is being protected?
 5. **Why** was there no published DPIA or ethical review before profiling officers' special-category and location data?
 6. **Why** Palantir, sole-sourced — when the same single-supplier failing led to the **blocking** of the separate ~£50m Unified Operational Analytics deal?
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3. What is confirmed

[confirmed] The pilot profiles the Met's own officers on Palantir. The "Unified Data Platform" is a professional-standards / "continuous integrity screening" pilot that brings the Met's internally-held employee data into **Palantir Foundry** to flag potential misconduct — analysing officers' **sickness and absence, overtime patterns, declared secondary employment, and data from work mobile phones and laptops including device geolocation.** The Metropolitan Police Federation called it "*outrageous,*" citing "*continuous 24/7 geolocation tracking.*" Sources: *Met Police news (Apr 2026)* <https://news.met.police.uk/news/metropolitan-police-strengthens-standards-using-technology-and-new-vetting-powers-508631> ; *Silicon UK* <https://www.silicon.co.uk/e-regulation/surveillance/met-police-palantir-629642> ; *The Nerve* <https://www.thenerve.news/p/met-police-palantir-officer-ai-surveillance-misconduct-extension-contract-federation>

[confirmed] £500,000 is the oversight line. Under the **MOPAC Scheme of Delegation and Consent (para 4.8)**, the **Deputy Mayor for Policing and Crime** must approve the award of contracts of **£500,000 or above**, and such decisions are taken as **published Policing and Crime Decisions** — the mechanism by which the public, the press and the London Assembly Police and Crime Committee see and can question MPS contracts. Below £500,000, none of that applies. Source: *MOPAC Scheme of Delegation and Consent / published decisions* — <https://www.london.gov.uk/programmes-strategies/mayors-office-policing-and-crime-mopac/mopac-governance-and-decision-making/mopac-decisions>

[confirmed] The bigger deal that went through the front door was blocked. The crime-intelligence work sits in a separate proposal — "**Unified Operational Analytics**" (UOA), **~£25.3m + £24.8m (~£50m)** — which **was** put to MOPAC and was **refused by the Deputy Mayor (Kaya Comer-Schwartz) on/around 20–21 May 2026**, citing the Met having "*only engaged with one potential supplier.*" Palantir is reported to be moving to sue. Sources: *Novara Media (21 May 2026)* <https://novaramedia.com/2026/05/21/sadiq-khan-blocks-50m-palantir-ai-deal-with-met-police/> ; *The Register (28 May 2026)* <https://www.theregister.com/public-sector/2026/05/28/london-cops-post-300m-tech-shopping-list-after-palantir-contract-blocked/5247685> ; *Local Government Lawyer* <https://www.localgovernmentlawyer.co.uk/procurement-and-contracts/402-procurement-news/100588-london-mayor-blocks-50m-metropolitan-police-deal-with-us-tech-company-palantir-claiming-met-only-engaged-with-one-potential-supplier>

The contrast is the substance: the £50m deal that *was* put up for approval was **stopped** for single-supplier procurement; the smaller pilot — same supplier — proceeded **below the line that would have triggered the same scrutiny.**

4. What is reported but NOT yet confirmed (handle with care)

- Reporting (The Nerve, attributing the figure to the Met's Contracts Finder notice) gives the original UDP work as **£489,999**, "*avoid[ing] hitting the £500,000 threshold for scrutiny.*" There are also indications the programme ran across **more than one contract** (an initial pilot plus the £489,999 work). **I have not been able to confirm the exact figures, or the number of contracts, against the primary Contracts Finder / MOPAC record** — Contracts Finder blocks automated access and the notice did not surface in searches. **The specific "£10,001 + £489,999 = £500,000" arithmetic is unverified and should not be stated as fact.**
- The **extension cost is undisclosed** ("commercially sensitive"), so the true aggregate is not public.

Therefore: treat the figures as **reported context**, and put the numbers to the Met as **questions** (§2.1) so they confirm them on the record. The oversight failure and the structure are the point; the exact pence are for the Met to disclose.

5. Why the structure matters: the law that names it

[confirmed — legal framework] Splitting a programme into sub-threshold contracts to avoid controls is prohibited. The pilot ran in 2026, under the **Procurement Act 2023** (in force 24 February 2025). **Section 4** restricts manipulating a contract's estimated value to avoid the Act's requirements; **Schedule 3, paragraph 4** is an express **anti-avoidance** rule — authorities **must not artificially subdivide a procurement** to evade the rules, and must estimate the **maximum** value **including options to extend**. Government guidance states "*rule-avoidance would never be a good reason*" to depart from aggregation. Sources: GOV.UK Procurement Act 2023 guidance — Valuation of Contracts <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/procurement-act-2023-guidance-documents-define-phase/guidance-valuation-of-contracts-html> ; Thresholds <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/procurement-act-2023-guidance-documents-define-phase/guidance-thresholds-html> (predecessor: PCR 2015 reg 6(3)).

So **if** the Unified Data Platform was delivered under more than one contract, the law required the Met to **aggregate** their value — which would engage the £500,000 MOPAC approval. Whether it did so is a question the Met can answer from its own records. The law is cited here to show **why the question is legitimate**, not to allege a breach.

6. Why it warrants the strongest scrutiny

- It is **AI surveillance of police officers' health, movements and devices**, on a US national-security contractor's platform — precisely the high-risk processing for which public oversight exists — and it proceeded with none.
- The sequencing looks like a **foot in the door**: a sub-threshold pilot, then a ~£50m operational deal (blocked).
- **Commercial sensitivity** was used to withhold the one figure that would show the true total.
- **No published DPIA, ROPA or ethical review** exists for the pilot.
- The **Nolan principles** (openness, accountability) are engaged whether or not any rule was formally broken.

7. Caveats (so it cannot be knocked down)

- **The exact contract figures and the number of contracts are reported, not confirmed by me against the primary record.** Do not state "£10,001 + £489,999 = £500,000" as fact. Put it to the Met as a question; confirm via the FOI below.
- **Intent is not established.** Whether the structure was a deliberate avoidance of the threshold is **the question to ask**, not a fact to assert.
- This concerns the **Metropolitan Police / Palantir** policing pilot — **separate** from the Ministry of Justice's Splink programme.

Definitive route to the figures: FOI to the **Metropolitan Police and MOPAC** — *"all contracts and contract values with Palantir relating to the Unified Data Platform, including any extensions"* — and a manual check of **Contracts Finder** and the **MOPAC contracts register**.

8. Sources

- The Nerve — Met/Palantir UDP pilot: <https://www.thenerve.news/p/met-police-palantir-officer-ai-surveillance-misconduct-extension-contract-federation>
- Met Police — "strengthens standards using technology": <https://news.met.police.uk/news/metropolitan-police-strengthens-standards-using-technology-and-new-vetting-powers-508631>
- Silicon UK — officer profiling: <https://www.silicon.co.uk/e-regulation/surveillance/met-police-palantir-629642>
- Novara Media — £50m UOA deal blocked: <https://novaramedia.com/2026/05/21/sadiq-khan-blocks-50m-palantir-ai-deal-with-met-police/>
- The Register — after the block: <https://www.theregister.com/public-sector/2026/05/28/london-cops-post-300m-tech-shopping-list-after-palantir-contract-blocked/5247685>
- Local Government Lawyer — single-supplier block: <https://www.localgovernmentlawyer.co.uk/procurement-and-contracts/402-procurement-news/100588-london-mayor-blocks-50m-metropolitan-police-deal-with-us-tech-company-palantir-claiming-met-only-engaged-with-one-potential-supplier>
- MOPAC Scheme of Delegation / decisions: <https://www.london.gov.uk/programmes-strategies/mayors-office-policing-and-crime-mopac/mopac-governance-and-decision-making/mopac-decisions>
- Procurement Act 2023 guidance — Valuation: <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/procurement-act-2023-guidance-documents-define-phase/guidance-valuation-of-contracts-html> — Thresholds: <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/procurement-act-2023-guidance-documents-define-phase/guidance-thresholds-html>
- Home Office WPQ UIN 7092 + answer: <https://questions-statements-api.parliament.uk/api/writtenquestions/questions?uin=7092&house=Commons>